

BHAGWANT MANN



SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL

Busy on their respective campaign trails, the Big Four of this Punjab election take time out to answer a few key questions, in exclusive interviews to Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Senior Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan. Excerpts

Q. What are the key issues in this election?

› CHARANJIT CHANNI: I come from a poor family. I know how hard it's for the poor to get their dal and rice. If the government keeps on providing aata and dal, it will only keep them poor. They need quality education and healthcare. I will ensure that. There are two kinds of society in the making. One, those who go to government schools and learn in Punjabi medium, and others who have access to private schools and learn in English. I am focused on providing quality education. Similarly, healthcare needs to be strengthened. We also need agro-based industry. To eradicate poverty, you need to focus on youngsters and, apart from providing them with quality education, we need to build an ecosystem that allows young people to launch startups. Even if they want to set up a transport business, cottage industry... the state should be the facilitator.

› BHAGWANT MANN: Unemployment is the biggest issue. It is at the core of many problems in our state. If unemployed, even those with MSc, MBBS or engineering degrees queue up for IELTS to go to Canada or Australia. It's brain drain. Every student going abroad drains Rs 25 lakh with him; a few years on, their family too migrates. Those who cannot clear IELTS or migrate fall into bad company or depression. Many resort to drug abuse. We want our students to be employed here. I haven't ever heard of anyone employed and taking drugs. Providing people jobs according to their educational skills and degrees is the main issue.

› SUKHBIR BADAL: We must take Punjab to the next level. People are expecting development and prosperity. To achieve that, Punjab needs a strong, decisive and passionate leadership. We don't need comedians but people who have the vision to build the state.